



Apex Predators



Eat or be eaten. That is the mantra of the animal kingdom. You might understand what a food chain is and what a predator is, but do you know what an apex predator is? What are they and why are they so important to our ecosystems and food chains?

Apex Predators

Plants sit at the bottom of the food chain. Plants are producers. Next, we have the herbivores who eat the plants, the primary consumers. Further up, we have the animals that eat the herbivores, the secondary consumers. At the top of the food chain, sits the apex predators.

Apex Predators

‘Apex’ refers to the top of something. An apex predator is an animal that is at the top of a food chain and has no natural predators. Nothing eats the apex predators. Examples of apex predators include bears and polar bears, whale sharks, crocodiles, komodo dragons, tigers and lions.

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Why are apex predators important?
Apex predators are important to ecosystems. They have big effects on animals and plants in the food chain. If an apex predator becomes extinct in a habitat, there can be detrimental changes further down the food chain as a result.

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Apex predators are carnivores and noted for their size, strength, speed and hunting ability. They attack their prey to feed. They have great senses like hearing and smell. They have sharp claws or jaws. And they have speed!

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The population of an apex predator is limited by how much food is available. Top level predators play a key role in controlling the population of other animals, and this can impact the food chain.

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Apex predators keep population numbers of their prey in check. Apex predators provide balance to food chains, habitats and ecosystems.

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